



Tern

# The Working Holiday Money Kit

**Land with your money sorted.**

The first-week checklist, the 45% tax trap, your superannuation refund, and the proof-of-funds numbers — everything in one place.

# Your first week: the money checklist

## Before you fly

- ☐ Open your account before departure — arrive with working account details so your employer can pay you from day one.
- ☐ Have your proof of funds ready as a clean, dated statement (see page 4 for what each country expects).
- ☐ Tell your home bank you're travelling; unblock foreign transactions on your cards.
- ☐ Screenshot/print your visa grant and insurance documents — border officers do ask.

## Day 1–2

- ☐ Get a local SIM or eSIM so banks and employers can reach you.
- ☐ Give your employer your local account details (in Australia: BSB + account number).
- ☐ Decline 'pay in your home currency' at every ATM and card machine — that's dynamic currency conversion, often a 5–12% hidden markup.

## Week 1

- ☐ Australia: apply for your TFN (free, [ato.gov.au](https://ato.gov.au)) the moment you have an address — without it your employer must withhold 45% tax.
- ☐ New Zealand: get your IRD number — without it you're taxed at the 45% no-notification rate.
- ☐ Canada: apply for your SIN (free) before starting work.
- ☐ Australia: nominate ONE super fund and reuse it for every job — job-hopping creates duplicate funds that quietly eat fees.
- ☐ Keep every payslip from your very first shift (you'll want them for tax refunds — and visa extensions).





# The 45% tax trap (and your refund)

Tax is where working holidaymakers quietly lose the most money — first to over-withholding, then by never claiming refunds. The cheat sheet:

## Australia

- ☐ No TFN given to your employer = 45% withholding on everything. With a TFN, working holidaymakers pay 15% on the first AUD 45,000.
- ☐ TFN is free and arrives in ~2 weeks. Apply on [ato.gov.au](https://ato.gov.au) — never pay an agent for this.
- ☐ Lodge a tax return after 30 June (or when leaving for good). Average backpacker refund: around \$2,600.
- ☐ Don't let an employer push you onto an ABN for normal wage work — that shifts their tax obligations onto you.

## New Zealand

- ☐ No IRD number = 45% no-notification rate. The catch: you need a functioning NZ bank account to get an IRD number — set banking up first.
- ☐ IRD auto-assesses most PAYE workers after the tax year (1 April–31 March); leaving early may need an IR3 return.

## Superannuation (Australia) — money people forget

- ☐ Your employer pays 12% of your wage into a super fund on top of your salary. It's yours.
- ☐ When you leave Australia for good, claim it back via DASP. It's taxed at 65% for WHV holders — but 35% of thousands of dollars is still real money.
- ☐ Keep your fund's name, member number and login. Billions sit unclaimed because backpackers lose track.

### Rule of thumb

A year of full-time work in Australia often means \$1,500–\$3,500 recoverable between your tax refund and DASP. Treat the paperwork as paid work.





# Proof of funds & first-month budget

## What immigration expects to see

- ☐ Australia (subclass 417/462): about AUD 5,000, plus evidence you can leave (onward ticket or extra funds).
- ☐ New Zealand: NZD 4,200 minimum, plus an onward ticket or the means to buy one.
- ☐ Canada (IEC): CAD 2,500, plus health insurance covering your whole stay — they can check it at the border.
- ☐ Carry it as a clean, recent bank statement in your name. Screenshots get questioned; formatted statements don't.

## A realistic first-month buffer

Budget 2–4 weeks of living costs before your first payday clears: hostel beds, food, SIM, transport, plus a rental bond if you move into a share house. Most travellers land comfortably with the visa minimum plus a month of costs — roughly AUD/NZD 5,000–7,000 all-in.

## Where money quietly leaks

- ☐ Airport currency counters (worst rates you'll ever see — exchange nothing there beyond taxi money).
- ☐ Foreign-card ATM fees: \$2–5 per withdrawal plus 1–3% — it compounds fast on cash-heavy farm life.
- ☐ Weekend FX markups on some travel cards.
- ☐ Bank transfers home with a 2–4% margin hidden in the exchange rate. Always compare against the mid-market rate you see on Google.

### The fix

Use an account with the real exchange rate, zero ATM fees, and local account details for payday. That's exactly what we're building at Tern — join the waitlist and you're in line from day one.







# Go deeper (free guides)

## Open an Australian account before you land

[whvwithtern.com/en/guides/bank-account-working-holiday-australia](https://whvwithtern.com/en/guides/bank-account-working-holiday-australia)

## The 45% backpacker tax, in full

[whvwithtern.com/en/guides/working-holiday-tax-refund-australia](https://whvwithtern.com/en/guides/working-holiday-tax-refund-australia)

## Claim your super back (DASP), step by step

[whvwithtern.com/en/guides/superannuation-refund-dasp](https://whvwithtern.com/en/guides/superannuation-refund-dasp)

## How much money you actually need (AU / NZ / CA)

[whvwithtern.com/en/guides/how-much-money-working-holiday-australia](https://whvwithtern.com/en/guides/how-much-money-working-holiday-australia)

## Your first week in Australia: full checklist

[whvwithtern.com/en/guides/first-week-money-checklist-australia](https://whvwithtern.com/en/guides/first-week-money-checklist-australia)

## Second-year visa: tracking your 88 days

[whvwithtern.com/en/blog/second-year-visa-88-days](https://whvwithtern.com/en/blog/second-year-visa-88-days)



## You're on the list — bring your crew.

Every friend who joins with your link moves you 10 spots up the waitlist. First 500: Founding Member perks. First 1,000: a free customisable metal card at launch.



